

and inform them about what they can do with them.

Affordances are like doors and windows in a building that help us enter a room or look outside. In electronic products, these are the input devices like switches, knobs, and sliders, or the output devices like displays, lights, and alarms. If we simply include a bunch of switches, dials, LEDs, and displays without providing any information, they will not make any sense. It is common practice to label or use visual representations to signify the purpose of a switch.

We must consider the user's culture when planning signifiers. Writing labels in English may have no meaning for rural populations who understand only the vernacular language. Many countries have regulations prohibiting the sale of products that provide instructions in a language unfamiliar to the local population. In multilingual countries like India, language-related issues are evident. Smart devices can address these issues with multilingual interfaces, while other devices often benefit from using pictures instead of words.

Even with pictures, we must consider the ethnic background of users. Some cultures read from left to right, while others read from right to left. Using a layout that requires controls to be used in a specific sequence may confuse users with different cultural backgrounds. Product designers must be sensitive to these cultural differences to avoid creating confusion.

In addition to controls, the overall look of the product itself communicates a story to the user. The styling, surface quality, and build quality convey the product's level of excellence. If the prospective buyer is put off by the appearance of the product, we don't even get a chance to engage with them. Aesthetics and styling are crucial.

Styling is an art that comes with practice. We can gain insights by studying different successful prod-

ucts. A fundamental aspect of styling is maintaining harmony among the product, fonts, icons, logo, and colour scheme. There are three basic genres of product styling.

Victorian style

Victorian design refers to the aesthetic and architectural style that emerged during the reign of Queen Victoria of the United Kingdom (1837-1901). This period witnessed significant industrial and technological advancements, and the design of the era reflected the opulence of the upper class and the impact of the Industrial Revolution.

Victorian design encompassed various architectural styles, including Gothic Revival, Italianate, Queen Anne, and Second Empire, among others. These styles often featured elaborate detailing, intricate ornamentation, and a fusion of different architectural elements. Elaborate woodwork, intricate carvings, and decorative mouldings adorned walls and ceilings. The colour palette ranged from rich, deep tones like burgundy and forest green to softer pastel shades.

Victorian design also emphasised the use of patterns and motifs. Floral patterns, damasks, and intricate wallpapers were popular choices for textiles and wall coverings. Elaborate tiling and mosaic work were incorporated into floors, fireplaces, and other surfaces. The overall effect was one of abundance and visual richness. This movement, led by influential designers such as William Morris, reacted against the mass-produced, ornate style of the time and sought to revive traditional artisan techniques.

Today, Victorian design continues to inspire and influence contemporary aesthetics. Elements of Victorian architecture and interior design can be found in many historic buildings, and the opulent and romantic aesthetic of the era is often

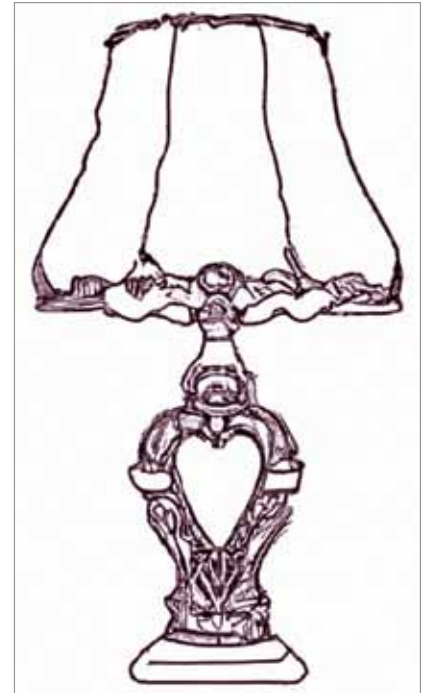


Fig. 1: Victorian table lamp

incorporated into modern interpretations of traditional styles. This style evokes a sense of rich abundance.

Bauhaus (Modern)

Bauhaus was a highly influential art and design school that operated in Germany from 1919 to 1933. It was founded by architect Walter Gropius with the goal of merging crafts and fine arts to create a new approach to design that would be functional, efficient, and aesthetically pleasing. The school's name, Bauhaus, literally translates to "building house" in German.

One of the key principles of Bauhaus design was the integration of art, craftsmanship, and technology. The school aimed to bridge the gap between traditional crafts and industrial mass production, combining new materials and manufacturing techniques with artistic sensibilities. It emphasised the importance of practicality and functionality in design, striving for simplicity and clarity of form.

Bauhaus design was characterised by several distinctive features. It em-